organizing secretary, was hand-picked by Shah to assist him in the UP campaign. The Hindi-speaking Bansal was from Rajasthan, did not have a foreign degree, but he had the common touch—he helped Shah set up a network of volunteers in Lucknow and every district headquarters. ‘Amitbhai is very organized. He likes to ensure everything is planned in advance,’ Bansal later told me.

A team of about 120 volunteers was ready by January 2014 to operate out of the party’s Lucknow head office. These volunteers helped set up and coordinate with the booth-level committees that are so critical to any election. Some of the volunteers were IITians, lawyers, management professionals, but a majority of them were drawn from the RSS–ABVP ranks. These volunteers coordinated with anywhere between 80,000 and one lakh swayamsevaks engaged in a massive door-to-door campaign. ‘Forget the technology, forget the media blitz, the 2014 election was ultimately a triumph of our foot soldiers who worked relentlessly on the ground in UP,’ is how a BJP strategist captured the party’s success story.

The RSS involvement was deep and intense. Each swayamsevak was referred to as a *panna pramukh* and made in charge of one page of a voter list (which has roughly around fifteen registered voters). Each booth has around 1200 votes, so eighty to ninety swayamsevaks were engaged in the campaign at every booth level. In a state with more than one lakh booths, this was election micromanagement being taken to a whole new level. ‘Our mission statement was every vote counts. We believed in the power of one,’ is how Bansal described the booth-centric approach.

The RSS campaign was divided into three phases. In the first phase, between Vijayadashmi in October 2013 and Republic Day in January 2014, the focus was on voter registration. In the second phase in February and March, the objective shifted to a door-to-door campaign aimed at around 6500 to 7000 villages in key districts. In the final stretch in April and May, the sole goal was to maximize voter turnout. ‘I don’t think that the RSS cadres have ever participated with such enthusiasm in any election since 1977. Even the Ayodhya election of 1991 was an emotional appeal to Hindutva. This time, we saw it as a fight to the finish. *Ek junoon tha worker*